PART II · TIME · 3

# How long is a note?

Sometimes a note needs a length no single shape gives, like three beats, or a sound that carries across the bar line. Two little signs stretch it.

**THE SECRET**
**A dot adds half. A tie glues two notes into one.**

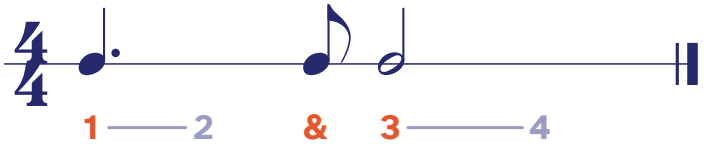


**2 beats** **2 + 1 = 3 beats**

*The dot adds half*

## The dot

A dot adds **half the note's value**: a dotted minim lasts 2 + 1 = 3 beats; a dotted crotchet 1 + ½ = 1½.



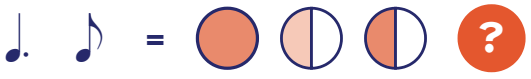

### The dot, in pizzas

The dot is a helper that adds **half of whatever its note is worth**. Dark slices: the note. Lighter: what the dot adds.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **dotted minim** |  | 2 + **1** (half of 2) = **3 beats** |
| **dotted crotchet** |  | 1 + **½** (half of 1) = **1½ beats** |
| **dotted quaver** |  | ½ + **¼** (half of ½) = **¾ beat** |

EXAMPLE 1

**How many beats: a dotted crotchet and a quaver?**




1. **The dotted crotchet:** 1 beat plus half of 1.
2. **The quaver:** half a beat.
3. **Add them.** Where does the quaver fall?

1½ + ½ = **2 beats**. The quaver lands on the "&" of beat 2: "1 (&) 2 **&**".

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EXAMPLE 2

**A dotted crotchet you already know: Ode to Joy**




1. **Bars 3–4 of Beethoven's Ode to Joy.** Sing it: "C C D E, E — D D".
2. **The red E is a dotted crotchet:** 1 + ½ = 1½ beats, held through "1 & 2".
3. **The quaver D** falls on the "&" of beat 2; the last D takes beats 3 and 4.

Long–short, then long: the dot is why the tune **leans** before it lands.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

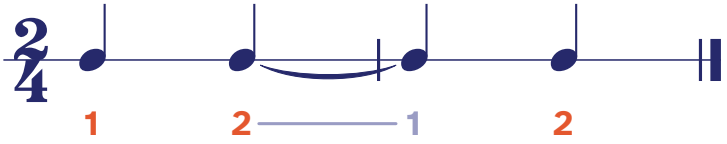
**The double dot**

A second dot adds half of the first dot. Rare before the higher Levels.




## The tie

A curve joining two notes **of the same pitch** makes one longer sound: play the first, hold through the second, and never play it again. Ties can cross a bar line, where a dot cannot.




EXAMPLE 3

**Dot or tie: which is longer?**




1. **The dotted minim:** a dot adds half. How many beats?
2. **The tied notes:** add the two notes together.
3. **Compare** the two totals.

Both last **3 beats**: the same length. A tie can also cross a bar line, which a dot cannot.

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EXAMPLE 4

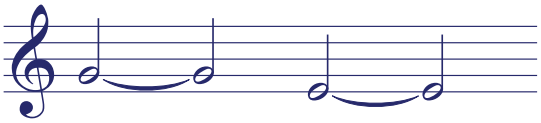
**Which is longer: a dotted minim or a minim tied to a quaver?**




1. **Dotted minim:** add half of 2. How many pizzas?
2. **Minim tied to a quaver:** add the two.
3. **Compare** the totals.

3 against 2½: the **dotted minim** is longer, by half a beat.

## Tie or slur?



**Tie**: the same pitch. Play once and hold: G for 4 beats, then E for 4.



**Slur**: different pitches. Play every note, smoothly joined (legato).

GAME

**How many beats?**



1 2 3

With a crotchet as one beat: how long does each one last?

Answer: 1 three (2 + 1) · 2 one and a half (1 + ½) · 3 three (2 tied to 1).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



**Clap once, hold for three.**

Say “1 2 3” as you hold: a dotted minim. Then a dotted crotchet and quaver: “1 (& 2) &”.

TRAP

- × Putting the dot on the wrong note: a dot adds half of **its own** note.
- × Tying two different pitches: that curve is a slur, not a tie.
- × Two kinds of dot: one **after** the head adds length; one **above or below** it means staccato.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 59 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 65

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: Library